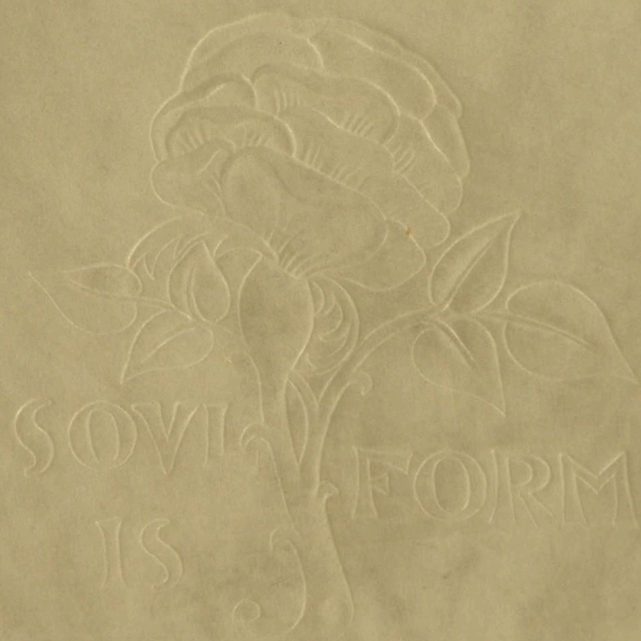




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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK
THE FLOWER AND THE LEAF ***



THE FLOWER AND THE LEAF.



And every plaine was eke yclothed faire

When that Phebus his
 chaire of gold so hie
 Hadde whirled up
 the sterrie sky alofte,
 And in the Boole
 was entred certainly:
 When shoures
 sweet of raine
 discended softe,
 Causing the ground,
 fele times & ofte,
 Up for to give many an
 wholesome aire,



season wexeth ful glad and light.

With newe green, and
 maketh smalle floures
 To springen here
 and there in field &
 mede; So very
 good & wholsome be
 the shoures, That
 it renueth that was old
 and dede In winter
 time; and out of every
 sede Springeth the
 hearbe, so that every
 wight Of this

And I, so glad of the season thus swete, Was happed thus
 upon a certaine night: As I lay in my bed, sleepe ful
 unmete Was unto me, but why that I ne mighte Rest,
 I ne wiste; for there nas earthly wight, As I suppose,
 hadde more heartes ease Than I, for I nadde sicknesse
 nor disease.



Wherefore I mervaille
greatly of myselfe,
That I withouten
sleepe so longe lay;
And up I rose
three houres after
twelwe, Aboute the
springing of the day,
And on I putte my
geare and mine array,
And to a pleasaunt
grove I gan to passe,
Long or the
bryghte Sonne uprisen
was;



In which were okes
great, streight as a line,
Under the which
the grasse, so fresh of
hewe, Was newly
sprong; and an eight
foot or nine Every
tree well fro his fellow
grew, With
branches brode, lade
with leves newe,

That sprongen out ayen the sunne shene, Some very red
and some a glad light grene;

Which, as me thoughte, was right a plesant sight; And
eke the briddes songes for to here Would have rejoiced
any earthly wight; And I, that couthe not yet, in no
manere, Heare the nightingale of all the year, Ful
busily herkened with hart & eare, If I her voice perceive
coud any where.



And, at the last, a path
of little breede I
found, that greatly
hadde not used be;
For it forgrowen was
with grasse & weede,
That well unneth a
wight ne might it se:
Thoght I, 'This
path some whider goth,
pardé!' And so I
followede, till it me
broughte To right
a pleasaunt herber, well
ywrought,



That benched was, &
eke with turfes new
Freshly turved,
whereof the grene gras,
So small, so
thicke, so short, so
fresh of hewe,
That most ylike greene
wool, I wot, it was:
The hegge also
that yede in this

compas, And closed in all the green herbere,
With sicamour was set and eglatere,

Wrethen in fere so well and cunningly,
That every branch
& leafe grew by mesure,
Plaine as a bord, of oon height
by & by. I ne segh never thing, I you ensure,
So well y-done; for he that tooke the cure
It for to make, Y
trow did all his peine To make it passe alle tho that men
have seine.



And shapen was this
herber, roofe and all,
As is a prety
parlour; & also
The hegge as thicke as
is a castle wall,
That who that list
without to stond or
go, Though he
would all day prien to
and fro, He
shoulde not see if there
were any wighte
Within or no; but one
within wel mighte.



Perceive Alle tho that
yeden there withoute
Into the field, that
was on every side
Covered with corne &
grasse; that out of
doubt, Though
one woulde seeke all
the worlde wide,
So rich a fielde ne
coude not be espide

On any coast, as of the quantitie; For of alle good
thing there was plentie.

And I that all this pleasaunt sight ay sie, Thought
sodainly I felte so sweete an aire Com of the eglentere,
that certainly There is no heart, I deme, in such dispaire,
Ne with no thoughtes froward and contraire So
overlaid, but it shoulde soone have bote, If it had ones
felt this savour sote.



And as I stood & cast
aside mine eie,  I
was of ware the fairest
medler tree,  That
ever yet in all my life I
sie,  As full of
blossomes as it mighte
be;  Therein a
goldfinch leaping
pretile  Fro bough
to bough; and, as him
list, gan eete  Of
buddes here and there
and floures sweete.



And to the herber side
ther was joyninge  This faire tree, of
which I have you told;
 And at the last the
brid began to singe,
 When he had
eaten what he eate
wolde,  So passing
sweetly, that by
manifolde  It was
more pleasaunt than I

coude devise.  And when his song was ended in this wise,

The nightingale with so mery a note  Answered him, that
all the woode rong  So sodainly, that, as it were a sote,
 I stood astonied; so was I with the song  Thorow
ravished, that till late and longe,  Ne wist I in what place I
was, ne where;  And ay, me thoughte, she song even by
mine ere.



Wherefore about I
waited busily, On
every side, if that I her
mighte see; And,
at the last, I gan full
well aspie Where
she sat in a fresh grene
laurer tree, On the
further side, even right
by me, That gave
so passing a delicious
smell, According
to the eglentere full
well.



Whereof I hadde so
inly great pleasure,
That, as me
thought, I surely
ravished was Into
Paradice, where as my
desire Was for to
be, and no ferther to
passe As for that
day; and on the sote
grasse I sat me
downe; for, as for mine
entent, The birddes song was more convenient,

And more pleasaunt to me by many fold, Than meat or
drinke, or any other thing. Therto the herber was so fresh
and cold, The wholesome savours eke so comforting,
That, as I demede, sith the beginning Of thilke
world was never seene or than So pleasaunt a ground of
none earthly man.



And as I sat, the
birddes harkening thus,
☞ Me thoughte that I
hearde voices sodainly,
☞ The most sweetest
& most delicious ☞
That ever any wight, I
trow truly, ☞ Heard
in here life; for sothe
the armony ☞ And
sweet accord was in so
good musike, ☞ That
the voices to angels
most was like.



And at the last, out of a
grove faste by, ☞
That was right goodly
& pleasant to sight,
☞ I sie where there
came, singing lustily,
☞ A world of ladies;
but, to tell aright ☞
Here grete beautie, it
lieth not in my might,
☞ Ne here array;
neverthelesse I shalle

☞ Telle you a part, though I speake not of alle.

The surcotes white, of velvet wele sitting, ☞ They were in
clad, & the semes echone, ☞ As it were a maner garnishing,
☞ Was set with emeraudes, one and one. ☞ But by and
by ful many a riche stone ☞ Was set on the purfiles, out of
doute, ☞ Of colors, sleeves, and traines round aboute.



As greate pearles,
round & oriente, 
Diamondes fine, and
rubies rede  And
many another stone, of
which I wente  The
names now; and
everich on her heade
 A riche fret of
gold, which, withoute
drede,  Was full
of stately riche stones
set;  And every
lady had a chapelet.



Upon her head of
floures fresh and
greene  So wele
ywrought & so
mervellously,  That
soth it was a noble
sight to seene;  Some of laurer, and
some full pleasantly
 Hadde chapelets
of woodbind, and sadly
 Some of agnus

castus were also  Chapelets freshe; but there were many
tho

That song & daunced, ekeful soberly,  And all they yede
in manner of compace;  But one there yede in mid the
company,  Soole by herselfe; but alle followede the pace
 Which that she kepte, whose heavenly faire face 
So pleasaunt was, and her wele shape person,  That of
beautie she past hem everichone.



And more richly
beseene, by manifold,
She was also in
every maner thing:
Upon her head,
full pleasaunt to
beholde, A crowne
of gold riche for any
kinge: A braunch
of agnus castus eke
bearing In her
hand; and to my sight
truly, She lady
was of al the company.



And she began a
roundell lustely,
That 'Suse le foyle,
devers moy,' men calle,
'Seen et mon joly
cuer est endormy;
And than the company
answered alle,
With voices sweet
entuned, and so smalle
That it me
thoughte the sweetest
melody That ever I heard in my life soothly.

And thus they came, dauncing & singing Into the
middest of the mede echone, Before the herber where I
was sitting; And, God wot, me thought I was wel bigone;
For then I might avise hem one by one, Who fairest
was, who coude best dance or singe, Or who most
womanly was in alle thinge.



They hadde not
daunced but a little
throwe, When that
I hearde not ferre off
sodainely, So
great a noise of
thundering trumpes
blow, As though it
should have departed
the skie; And,
after that, within a
while I sie, From
the same grove where
the ladies come oute,
Of men of armes
coming such a route,

As alle the men on
earth hadde ben
assembled In that
place, wele horsed for
the nones, Stering
so faste, that al the
earth trembled:
But for to speake of
riches and of stones,
And men and

horse, I trow the large wones Of Prestir John, ne all his
tresorie, Mighte not unneth have boght the tenth partie

Of here array: who so list heare more, I shall rehearse so
as I can a lite. Out of the grove, that I of spake before,
I sie come first, all in here clokes white, A company,
that ware, for here delite, Chapelets fresh of okes
serialle, Newly yspronge, and trumpets they were alle.



On every trumpe
 hanging a broad banere
 Of fine tartarium
 ful richely bete;
 Every trumpet his
 lordes armes bere;
 About here neckes,
 with greate pearles
 sete, Colleres
 brode; for cost they
 woulde not lete,
 As it woulde seeme,
 for here scochones
 echone Were set
 aboute with many a
 precious stone.

Here horse harneis was
 all white also. And
 after hem next, in one
 company, Came
 kinges of armes, & no
 mo, In clokes of
 white cloth of gold
 richly; Chapelets
 of greene on here
 heades on hie;

The crownes that they on here scochones bere, Were set
 with pearle, ruby, and saphere,

And eke great diamondes many one: But all here horse
 harneis & other geare Was in a sute accordinge,
 everychone, As ye have heard the foresaid trumpets
 were; And, by seeming, they were nothing to lere,
 And here guiding they dide so manerly. And, after hem,
 came a great company



Of heraudes and
pursevauntes eke, 
Arrayed in clothes of
whit velvette, 
And, hardily, they were
no thing to seke, 
How they on hem
shoulde the harneis
sette;  And every
man had on a chapelet;
 Scochones and
eke horse harneis,
indede,  They had
in sute of hem that
before hem yede.

Next after hem camen,
in armour bright 
All save here heades,
seemely knightes nine;
 And every claspe
and naile, as to my
sight,  Of here
harneis were of red
golde fine;  With
cloth of gold, and
furred with ermine 

Were the trappores of here stedes strong,  Wide and large,
that to the ground dide honge.

And every bosse of bridle & paitrell  That hadde they,
was worth, as I woulde wene,  A thousand pound; and on
here heades, well  Dressed, were crowns of laurer grene,
 The best ymade that ever I hadde sene;  And every
knight had after him riding  Three henshemen on him ay
awaiting.



Of which every first,
on a short tronchoun,
His lordes helme
bare, so richly dight,
That the worst
was worth the ransoun
Of any king; the
second a shield bright
Bare at his backe;
the thridde bare upright
A mightie spere,
full sharpe yground
and kene, And
every child eke ware of
leaves grene

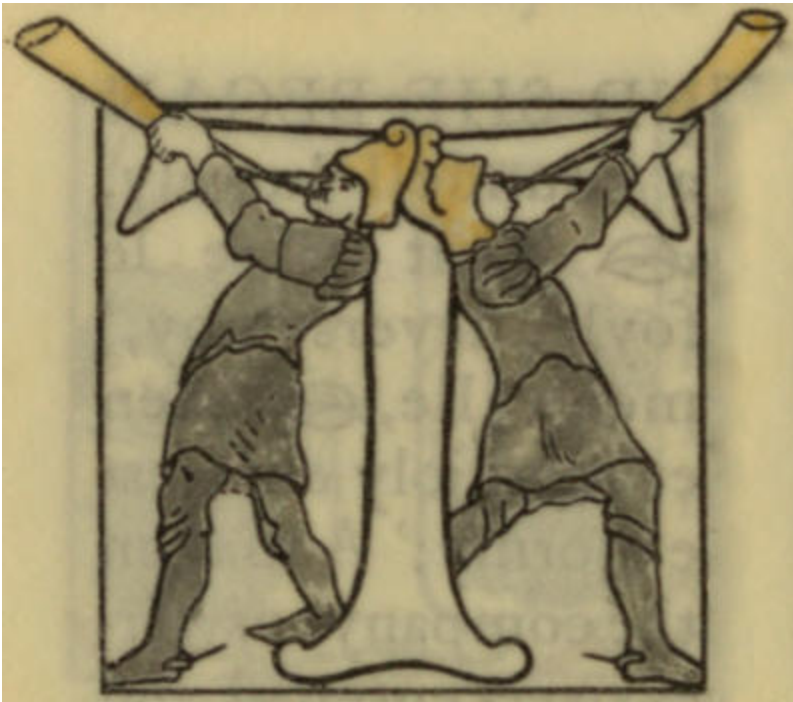
A fresh chapelet upon
his haire brighte:
And clokes white of
fine velvet they were;
Here steedes
trapped & arraied
righte, Without
difference, as here
lordes were; And
after hem, on many a
fresh corsere,

There came of armede knightes such a route, That they
bespradde the large field aboute.

And all they ware, after here degrees, Chapelets newe
made of laurer grene; Some of the oke, and some of
other trees, Some in here hondes bare boughes shene,
Some of laurer, and some of okes kene, Some of
hauthorne, and some of the woodbind, And many mo
which I hadde not in mind.



And so they came, here
 horses freshly stering
 With bloodie
 sownes of her trompes
 loude; There sie I
 many an uncouth
 disguising In the
 array of these knightes
 proude; And at the
 last, as evenly as they
 coude, They took
 here places in middes
 of the
 mede,
 And every
 knight
 turned his
 horse hede



To his
 fellow, &
 lightly laid
 a spere
 In the
 arest; & so
 justes
 began
 On every
 part

abouten, here & there; Some brake his spere, some drew
 down hors & manne; Aboute the field astray the steedes
 ranne; And, to behold here rule and governaunce, I
 you ensure, it was a great pleasaunce.

And so the justes last an houre and more; But tho that
 crowned were in laurer grene Wanne the prise; here



dintes were so sore,
 That there was
 none ayenst hem
 mighte sustene:
 And the justing all was
 yleft off clene,
 And fro here horse the
 ninth alight anone,
 And so did all the
 remnant everichone.

And forth they yede
 togider, twain and
 twain, That to
 behold it was a worthy
 sight, Toward the
 ladies on the greene
 plaine, That song
 & daunced, as I saide
 now righte: The
 ladies tho, soone as
 they goodly mighte,
 They braken of
 bothe the song and
 dance, And yede
 to meet hem with ful
 glad semblance.

And every lady tooke, full womanly, By the right hond a
 knight, & forth they yede Unto a faire laurer that stood
 fast by, With leves lade, the boughes of great brede;
 And to my dome there never was, indede, Man that
 hadde seene halfe so faire a tree; For underneath there
 might it well have be



An hundred persons, at
 here owne plesance,
 ☞ Shadowed fro the
 heat of Phebus bright,
 ☞ So that they
 shoulde have felt no
 grevaunce ☞ Of
 raine ne haile that hem
 ne hurte mighte. ☞
 The savour eke rejoice
 would any wighte ☞
 That hadde be sicke or
 melancolius, ☞ It
 was so very good and
 vertuous.



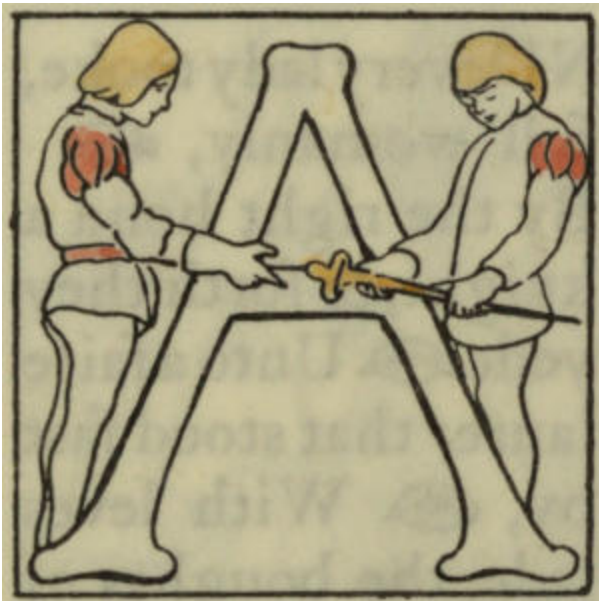
untrewe, ☞ Envirouninge the tree that stood upright; ☞
 And ever yede a lady and a knight.



















And at the last mine eye I caste aside,  And was ware of a
lustie company  That came roming out of the field wide,
 Hond in hond a knight and a lady;  The ladies all in
surcotes, that richely  Purfiled were with many a rich
stone,  And every knight of grene ware mantles on,



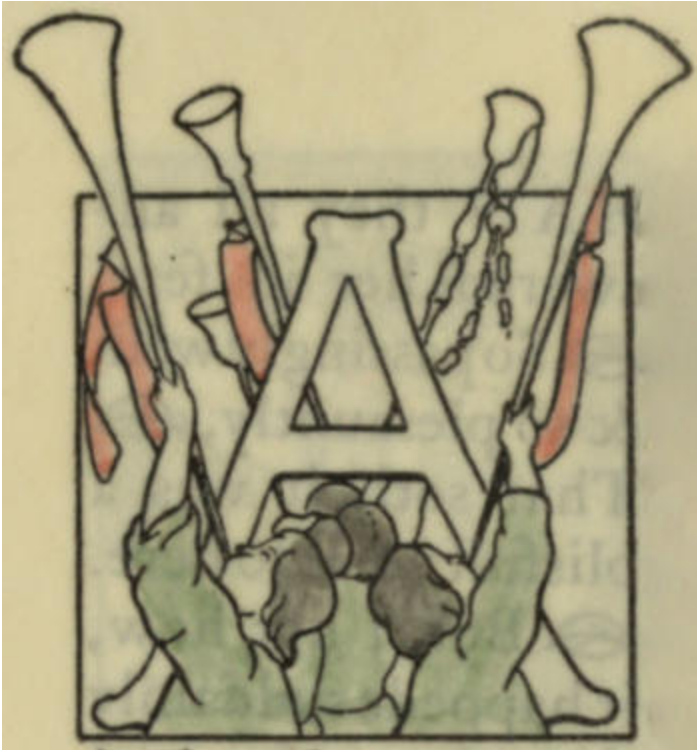
Embrouded well so as
the surcotes were: 
And everich had a
chapelet on her hede,
 Which dide right
well upon the shining
here  I-made of
goodly floures white
and rede;  The
knightes eke, that they
in hond gan lede, 
In sute of hem ware
chapelets everychone,
 And before hem
wente minstrels many
one.



As harpes, pipes, lutes,
and sautry,  All in
greene; and on here
heades bare,  Of
divers floures, made
full craftely,  All in
a sute, goodly
chapelets they ware;
 And, so dauncing,
into the mede they fare.
 In mid the which
they found a tuft that

was  Al oversprad with floures in compas.

Whereto they enclined everychone  With great reverence,
and that full humbly;  And, at the laste, there began anone
 A lady for to singe right womanly  A bargaret in
praising the daisie;  For, as me thought, among her notes
swete,  She said 'Si douse est la Margarete.'



Than they all
answered her in
fere, So
passingly well,
& so plesauntly,
That soth it
was a blisfull
noise to here.
But, I not
how, it happede
suddainly
As aboute noone,
the sonne so
fervently
Waxe hote, that
the pretie tendre
floures



Hadde lost the beautie
of her freshe colours,

Forshronke with heat;
the ladies eke to-brent,
That they ne wiste
where hem to bestowe;
The knightes
swelte, for lack of
shade nie shent;
And after that, within a
little throwe, The
wind began so sturdily

to blowe, That down goeth alle the floures everichone,
So that in all the mede there laft not one;

Save such as succoured were among the leves Fro every
storme that mighte hem assaile, Growing under hedges
and thicke greves; And after that there came a storme of



haile And raine in
fere, so that, withouten
faile, The ladies
ne the knightes nade o
threed Drie upon
hem, so dropping was
her weed.

And whan the storm
was cleane passed
away, Tho clad in
white that stode under
the tree, They
felte nothing of the
great affray, That
they in greene without
had in ybe; To
hem they yede for
routhe and pité,
Hem to comfort after
here greate disease,
So faine they were
the helplesse for to
ease.



Than was I ware how
one of hem in grene

Had on a crowne, ful rich and wel sitting;
Wherefore I demed wel she was a quene,
And tho in greene on her were awaiting;
The ladies then in white
that were comming Towardes hem, and the knightes in
fere, Beganne hem to comfort, and make hem chere.

The queen in white, that was of great beauty,
Tooke by the hond the queen that was in grene,
And said, 'Suster, I
have right great pitie Of your annoy, and of the troublous



tene,  Wherein ye
and your company
have bene  So
long, alas! and if that it
you please  To go
with me, I shall do you
the ease,

In all the pleasure that I
can or may;’ 
Whereof the tother,
humbly as she mighte,
 Thanked her; for
in right ill array 
She was with storm
and heat, I you
behighte;  And
every lady, then anone
right,  That were in
white, one of hem took
in grene  By the
hond; which when the
knightes hadde sene,



In like wise ech of hem
tooke hir a knight 
I-clad in greene, &

forth with hem they fare,  Unto an hegge, where they
anon gan right  To make here justes, woulde they not
spare  Boughes to hewe down, and eke trees square, 
Wherwith they made hem stately fires greate,  To dry
here clothes that were wringing weate.

And after that, of hearbes that there grewe,  They made,
for blisters of the sunne brenning,  Very good &
wholesome ointmentes newe,  Where that they yede the



sicke fast anointing;
 And after that they
 yede aboute gadering
 Pleasaunt salades,
 which they made hem
 eate, For to
 refresh here grete
 unkindly heate.

The lady of the Leafe
 then gan to praye
 Her of the Floure (for
 so to my seeming
 They shoulde be, as by
 here arraye) To
 soupe with her, & eek,
 for any thing, That
 she shoulde with her all
 her people bringe;
 And she ayen, in right
 goodly manere,
 Thanketh her of her
 most friendly cheare,

Saying plainely, that
 she would obaye
 With all her hart all her
 commaundement; And then, anon, withoute lenger
 delaye, The lady of the Leafe hath one ysent For a
 palfray, as after her intent, Arrayed well and faire in
 harneis of golde, For nothing lacked, that to him long
 sholde.

And after that, to all her company She made to purvey
 horse and every thing That they needed; & then ful
 lustily, Even by the herber where I was sitting, They



passed alle, so
pleasantly singing,
That it would have
comforted any wight.
But then I sie a
passing wonder sight;

For then the
nightingale, that all the
day Had in the
laurer sete, & did her
might The whole
service to singe
longing to May,
All sodainly began to
take her flight;
And to the lady of the
Leafe, forthright,
She flew, and set her
on her hond softly,
Which was a thing I
marveled of greatly.

The goldfinch eke, that
fro the medler tree
Was fled for heat into
the bushes colde,

Unto the lady of the Flower gan flee, And on her hond he
set him as he wolde, And pleasauntly his winges gan to
folde; And for to singe they pained hem both, as sore
As they hadde do of all the day before.

And so these ladies rode forth a great pace, And all the
rout of knightes eke in fere; And I that hadde seene all
this wonder case, Thought I would assay in some
manere, To knowe fully the trouth of this matere;



And what they were
that rode so pleasantly.

And when they
were the herber passed
by,

I dreste me forth, and
happede to mete anone

Right a faire lady,
I you ensure; And
she come riding by
herselfe alone, All
in white; with

semblance ful demure

I salued her, and
bad her good aventure

Might her befall,
as I coude most
humbly; And she
answered, 'My
doughter, gramercy!'

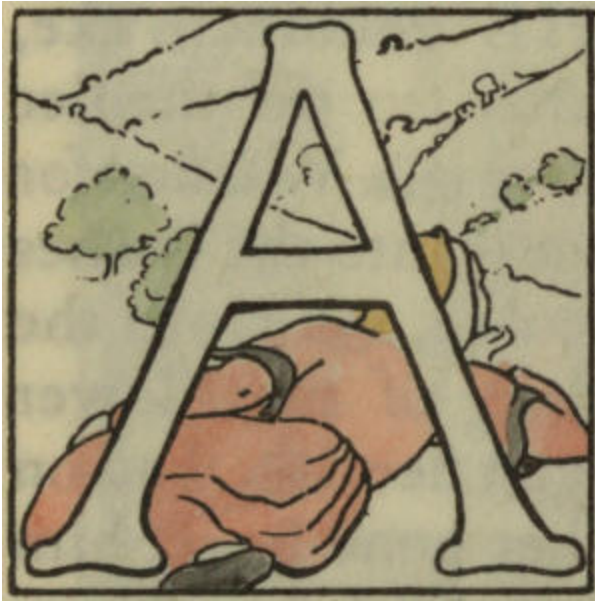
'Madame,' quod I, 'if
that I durst enquire

Of you, I woulde
faine, of that company,

Wite what they be

that paste by this arbere?' And she ayen answerede right
friendly: 'My faire doughter, all tho that passed here by
In white clothing, be servaunts everichone Unto the
Leafe, and I myselfe am one.

See ye not her that crowned is,' quod she, 'All in
white?'—'Madame,' quod I, 'yis:' 'That is Diané,
goddesse of chastité; And for because that she a maiden
is, In her own hond the braunch she beareth iwis,



That agnus castus men
 calle properly; 
 And all the ladies in
 her company,

Which as ye se of that
 hearb chapelets weare,
 Be such as han
 kept alway hir
 maidenheed:  And
 alle they that of laurer
 chapelets beare, 
 Be such as hardy were,
 and manly indeed, 
 Victorious name which
 never may be dede!
 And alle they
 were so worthy of here
 honde,  That in her
 time none might hem
 withstonde.

And tho that weare
 chaplets on here hede
 Of fresh
 woodbind, be such as
 never were  To

love untrue in word, in thought, ne dede,  But aye
 stedfast; ne for pleasaunce, ne fere,  Thogh that they
 shuld here hertes al to-tere,  Woulde ne flitte, but ever
 were stedfaste,  Til that here lives there asunder braste.'

'Now faire madame,' quod I, 'yet would I pray  Your
 ladiship, if that it mighte be,  That I mighte knowe, by
 some maner way,  (Sith that it hath i-liked your beauté,
 The trouth of these ladies for to telle me);  What that



these knightes be in
rich armour, And
what tho be in grene
and weare the flour?

And why that some
dide reverence to the
tre, And some
unto the plot of floures
faire?' 'With right
good will, my fair
doghter,' quod she,
'Sith your desire
is good and debonaire;
Tho nine crowned
be very exemplaire
Of all honour
longing to chivalry;
And those certaine
be called the Nine
Worthy,



Which ye may see now
riding all before
That in her time dide
many a noble dede,
And for here

worthinesse full oft have bore The crowne of laurer
leaves on here hede, As ye may in your olde bookes rede;
And how that he that was a conquerour, Hadde by
laurer alway his most honour.

And tho that beare bowes in here honde Of the precious
laurer so notable, Be such as were, I woll ye
understonde, Noble knightes of the rounde table,



And eke the
Douseperis honourable,
Which they
bearen in signe of
victory; It is
witness of here deedes
mightily.



Eke there be knightes
old of the garter,
That in her time dide
right worthily;
And the honour they
dide to the laurer,
Is for by it they have
here laud wholly,
Here triumph eke, and
marshall glory;
Which unto hem is
more parfit richesse,
Than any wight
imagine can or gesse.

And it be done so as it oughte to be, Is more honour than
anything earthly; Witnesse of Rome that founder was
truly Of all knighthood and deedes marvelous;
Record I take of Titus Livius.

And as for her that crowned is in greene, It is Flora, of
these floures goddess; And all that here on her awaiting
beene, It are such folk that loved idelnesse, And not



delite hadde of no
 businesse, But for
 to hunt and hauke, and
 pley in medes,
 And many other such
 idle dedes.

And for the grete
 delite and pleasaunce
 They have to the
 floure, and so
 reverently They
 unto it do such grete
 obeisaunce As ye
 may se.—‘Now faire
 Madame,’ quod I,
 ‘If I durst aske what is
 the cause and why,
 That knightes
 have the signe of
 honour, Wel rather
 by the leafe than by the
 flour?’



‘Soothly, doughter,’
 quod she, ‘this is the
 trouth: For

knightes ever should be persevering,
 To seeke honour
 without feintise or slouth,
 Fro wele to better in all
 manner thing; In signe of which, with leaves aye lasting
 They be rewarded after here degré, Whose lusty
 green may not appaired be,

But aie keping here beautie fresh & greene; For there nis
 storme that ne may hem deface, Ne haile nor snow, ne
 winde nor frostes kene; Wherfore they have this



propertie and grace.
And for the floure,
within a little space
Will be i-lost, so
simple of nature
They be, that they no
greevance may endure;

And every storme will
blow hem soone
awaye, Ne laste
they not but for oon
season; That is the
cause, the very trouth
to saye, That they
maye not, by no way of
reason, Be put to
no such occupation.'
'Madame,' quod I,
'with all mine whole
servise I thanke
you now, in my most
humble wise;

For now I am
acertained throughly,
Of every thing I

desired to knowe.' 'I am right glad that I have said,
sothly, Ought to your pleasure, if ye wille me trowe,'
Quod she ayen, 'but to whom do ye owe Your
service? and which wolle ye honoure, Tel me I pray, this
yere, the Leafe or the Floure?'

'Madame,' quod I, 'though I be least worthy, Unto the
Leafe I owe mine observaunce': 'That is,' quod she, 'right
well done certainly; And pray I God to honour you avaunce,



And kepe you fro
the wicked
remembraunce Of
Malebouch, and all his
crueltie, And all
that good and well
conditioned be.

For here may I no
lenger now abide,
I muste followe the
greate company,
That ye maye see
yonder before you
ride.' And tho forth, as
I couthe, most humbly,
I tooke my leve of
her, as she gan hie
After hem as fast as
ever she mighte;
And I drow homeward,
for it was nigh nighte,

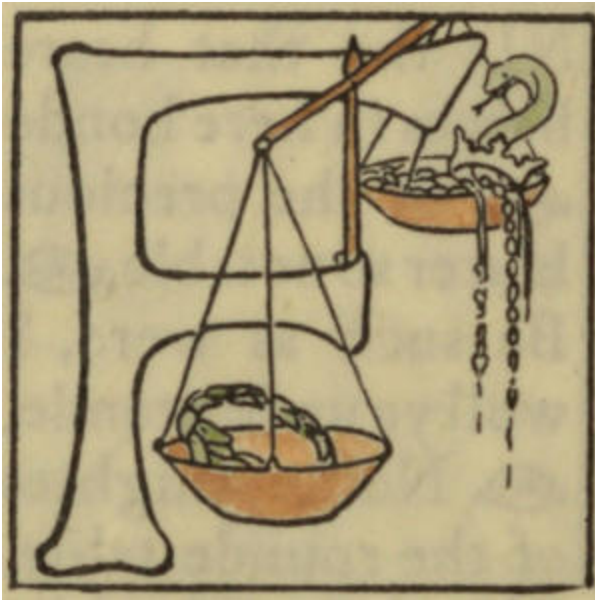
And put all that I hadde
seene in writing,
Under support of hem
that lust it to rede.

O little booke, thou art so unconning,
How darst thou put
thysself in prees, for drede?
It is wonder that thou wexest
not rede!
Sith that thou wost full lite who shall beholde
Thy rude language, ful boistously unfolde.



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